dynasty mention police officers (‘dandanayakas’), judges, and even a council of the ‘heir apparent’.

These are not the methods by which Ashoka makes his political authority visible. There are no imperial portraits on coins or sculpture. Nor are there courtly structures where one might imagine the emperor living with his family and in the proximity of core commanders and ministers. Instead, the artifact indisputably Ashokan is the epigraph. His political reach is best visualized via these written objects, which mark out the Mauryan empire of his time. Many later kings would also appear as rulers through words they inscribed, but Ashoka is distinguishable from them because he so conspicuously shuns the standard regal template of boasting about material possession and territorial grandeur. He does not set down messages proclaiming battles won and empire augmented. He proclaims himself, instead, as a man of strong intellect seeking to convert subjects to his point of view instead of demanding their blind obedience. And he wants to convert them by inscribing his messages near the places where they live, where they worship, along pathways that travellers use and the hilltops overlooking them.

The success of these interventions on the ground is, of course, difficult to judge. But what is beyond dispute is the fact that Ashoka had through his major edicts advanced the notion of a fundamentally new kind of political and social community.